

Marketing attribution for a small business: which leads did your ads actually produce?

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PRIVATE REVIEW EDITION · SEPTEMBER 2026

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Source: 10-marketing-attribution-small-business-which-leads-ads-produced.md

Typography: Archivo Black display, Georgia reading text and Calibri utility text. Georgia is a print-specific reading choice; the existing Momentum web design system is unchanged.

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title: "Marketing attribution for a small business: which leads did your ads actually produce?" slug: marketing-attribution-small-business-which-leads-ads-produced target_query: "what is attribution in marketing", "marketing attribution" and "call tracking" intent: informational feeds_ebook: "E - Names, Not Numbers" meta_description: "Why the platform's conversion count and your phone disagree, the three plumbing fixes, a spreadsheet match-back, and what to demand from any agency." publish_week: 6 publish_gate: "Per the calendar, hold this post until the match-back Zap fix has landed on Momentum's own accounts and one month of named-lead reporting exists. Until then, run the week-1 baseline re-measurement post in this slot. The post claims no match-back capability; it teaches the method and tells the defect honestly." sources: - C:\Users\dillo\Documents\Codex\projects\client-operations\clients\momentum-360\deliverables\2026-09-07-google-aistudio-batch\research\aeo-geo-topic-research.md - C:\Users\dillo\Documents\Codex\projects\client-operations\clients\momentum-360\deliverables\2026-09-07-google-aistudio-batch\research\evidence-bank.md - C:\Users\dillo\Documents\Codex\projects\client-operations\clients\momentum-360\deliverables\2026-09-04-ai-division-plan\PLAN.md - C:\Users\dillo\Documents\Codex\projects\client-operations\clients\momentum-360\deliverables\2026-07-26-paid-media-reporting-contract.md

Marketing attribution for a small business: which leads did your ads actually produce?

By Dillon Mohr, Momentum Digital, Philadelphia

Marketing attribution is knowing which real people your marketing produced, by name, and where each one came from. Not the platform's conversion count. The count and your phone disagree because they measure different things. Three plumbing fixes close the gap: a tracking number, a form email that carries the lead's details, and a source field in your CRM.

This is the post where I tell you what we got wrong, because it's the only honest way into the subject.

What is attribution in marketing, in plain terms?

"What is attribution in marketing" gets about 480 searches per month in the US. "Marketing attribution" gets 720, and it's been falling for two years, from 1,600 a month. The pages that answer it are an attribution software vendor, Amazon Ads, Supermetrics, Wikipedia and Adobe. Enterprise words for enterprise budgets.

For a business with a phone, a form and a front desk, it's three questions. Which person. Which source. Which job. If your report can't put a name in the first column, it isn't attribution. It's a platform screenshot.

Why don't my ad platform's conversions match my phone?

Because a conversion is an event a tag fired, and a lead is a person. Three examples from our own accounts in 2026, with the names removed because the owners haven't agreed to be named.

A Northern California concrete and landscape contractor's Google Ads account reported 87 conversion events across three overlapping 28-day windows. The account had 14 conversion actions switched on, including duplicate primaries for forms, calls, contacts and click-to-call. The same phone call could count three times. Our own audit wrote it plainly: 87 events cannot be presented as 87 estimate leads.

A Colorado Springs landscaping contractor's campaign showed 13 conversions. Four of them came from searches for a competitor's name, and the owner's complaint at the time was that callers thought they'd reached another company or a supplier. The platform counted all thirteen. Four of them were people looking for someone else.

A Philadelphia bridal boutique's campaign served 54,814 impressions and spent \$585.42 over 30 days while reporting zero conversions. Whether that meant no inquiries or a tracking path that was never wired, nobody could say from the platform alone. So we didn't touch the budget until the form path was proved end to end.

None of those platforms lied. They counted what they were told to count. The gap is in what they were told.

What is call tracking and do I need it?

"Call tracking" gets about 1,600 searches per month in the US, and "call tracking software" another 880. It's a phone number per source that forwards to your real line and logs every call: the number that came in, when, on which line, how long.

You need it if you run ads. Put a tracking number on each paid source and on your landing pages. Keep your real number on your Google Business Profile and your listings, consistent everywhere, so you don't confuse the machines that read those.

Call tracking tells you what happened. It doesn't answer the phone. On our own agency line in July 2026, through the 27th, it told us: 263 inbound calls, 101 answered, 162 missed, every call linked to a contact record, and an owner assigned on none of them. Useful. Also humbling.

What are the three plumbing fixes?

1. **A tracking number per paid source.** Google Ads gets one. Meta gets one. The website gets its own. Now every call has a source before anyone picks up.
2. **A form notification email that carries the fields.** The lead's name, phone, email, what they asked, and the source parameters from the link they clicked. In the body of the email. Not a link to go look.
3. **A source field in your CRM, required at intake.** One row per lead. Nobody saves the row without filling in where it came from.

Three fixes, all of them settings. None of them a report.

What is the one integration change that makes or breaks it?

Number two on that list. Here's how we learned it.

This month we audited four of our own client accounts to answer the question in this post's title. On three of them, the automation that sends lead notifications delivered an email with one line in it: a link to open the run in the automation tool. No name. No phone. No source. On the fourth account, the same tool had been configured to parse the lead's fields into the body of the email. That was the only account of the four where we could put a name next to a conversion.

One configuration setting. We'd promised named-lead reports on the other three accounts more than once, and couldn't produce them, and the reason was one setting in the notification step.

So here's where we stand. We're fixing our own configuration first. I'm not selling anyone a named-lead match-back until it's true on every account we run, and I'll publish the first real month when it exists. If an agency promises you one, ask to see one month of it, with names blacked out and dates left in.

How do I do a match-back with a spreadsheet?

Three tabs.

Platform. One row per conversion the platform counted: date, campaign, conversion action, count.

Leads. One row per real person: date, name, phone, source (from the tracking number or the form parameters), disposition.

Jobs. One row per booked job: name, booked date, value.

Match Platform to Leads on date and source. Match Leads to Jobs on name or phone. Then report five numbers: conversions counted, named leads found, matched, unmatched, booked.

The unmatched column is the honest one. It's where the platform counted something you can't find a person for. Print it. Every month. An agency that hides that column is hiding the gap this whole post is about.

What should I demand from any agency, including us?

Our own reporting contract, the rules every ad report we produce has to follow:

- Platform events reported separately from business outcomes, always.
- The chain in order: leads received, deduplicated, contacted, qualified, booked, won, revenue.
- Tests and duplicates excluded before counting.
- Whole numbers. No fractional leads.
- "Pending validation" written on any line where the definition isn't defensible.

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- A platform screenshot is not a report.

The line from that document I'd put on the wall: "Platform activity is reported separately from qualified inquiries, appointments, estimates, bookings, and revenue."

Hold us to it. Hold everyone to it.

FAQ

What's the difference between marketing attribution and lead attribution? Marketing attribution is the general idea. Lead attribution is the version that matters for a service business: which named lead came from which source.

Do I need a CRM for this? You need a place with one row per lead and a required source field. A spreadsheet qualifies. "CRM for small business" gets about 3,600 searches per month in the US, so people want software, but the field matters more than the software.

Can Google Ads tell me which leads it produced? It can tell you which conversion events it counted. Naming the person needs your form, your phone log and your CRM to carry the source. That's the plumbing above.

The next step

If you want to know whether your leads can be named at all today, I'll do a 15-minute snapshot: three observations about how your leads are captured, with the evidence for each, and one suggested next step. Free. No deck, no pitch. Reach me through needmomentum.com.